PRESIDENTIAL ELECTION 2022

THE NEXT BIG BATTLE

Come July 24 and President Ram Nath Kovind's tenure will come to an end. It will be time soon, therefore, to choose his successor. According to convention, the election for the office of the President of India is notified in mid-June and polling begins in July. Sixty-six Rajya Sabha members will retire by mid-July and be replaced by new members elected in polls to be held through the year, including 13 who'll be elected on March 31 and get to participate in the presidential poll.

The BJP's four-state win in the recent assembly polls in five states has put the party on a firm wicket for the presidential elections with a collective vote value of 465,797. Add to that the vote value of its NDA partners: 71,329. As the electoral college has a total of 1,098,903 votes, the BJP needs 549,452 votes to get the President of its choice elected. With the Jammu and Kashmir assembly suspended, the absence of its 87 seats with a vote value of 6,264 brings down the majority mark by 3,132, but the BJP is still short by 9,194 votes. The party, therefore, needs a new ally to sail through, possibly the Naveen Patnaik-led Biju Janata Dal or the Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy-led YSRCP.

For the BJP, the presidential election is an opportunity to send a strong message ahead of the 2024 general election. Last time, the party and its ideological fountainhead the RSS, had managed to send Kovind, a Dalit, to the Rashtrapati Bhawan. This time, they want someone from an underprivileged or geographically under-represented community to be elected to the top job. Several names have been doing the rounds, but no candidate has been confirmed yet. ■

–Anilesh S. Mahajan

BJP'S ARITHMETIC TO WIN PRESIDENCY

TOTAL ELECTORAL COLLEGE VOTES	:	**1,098,903**
VOTES NEEDED BY THE BJP TO WIN	:	**546,320***
VOTES THE BJP HAS CURRENTLY	:	**537,126**
BALANCE NEEDED TO CLINCH IT	:	**9,194**

RAJYA SABHA

BJP **68,676** | ALLIES **12,036**

The 233-member house has 708 votes for each member; the BJP has 97 members in the upper house, along with its allies' 17. It is expected to win 28 seats with no gains.

LOK SABHA

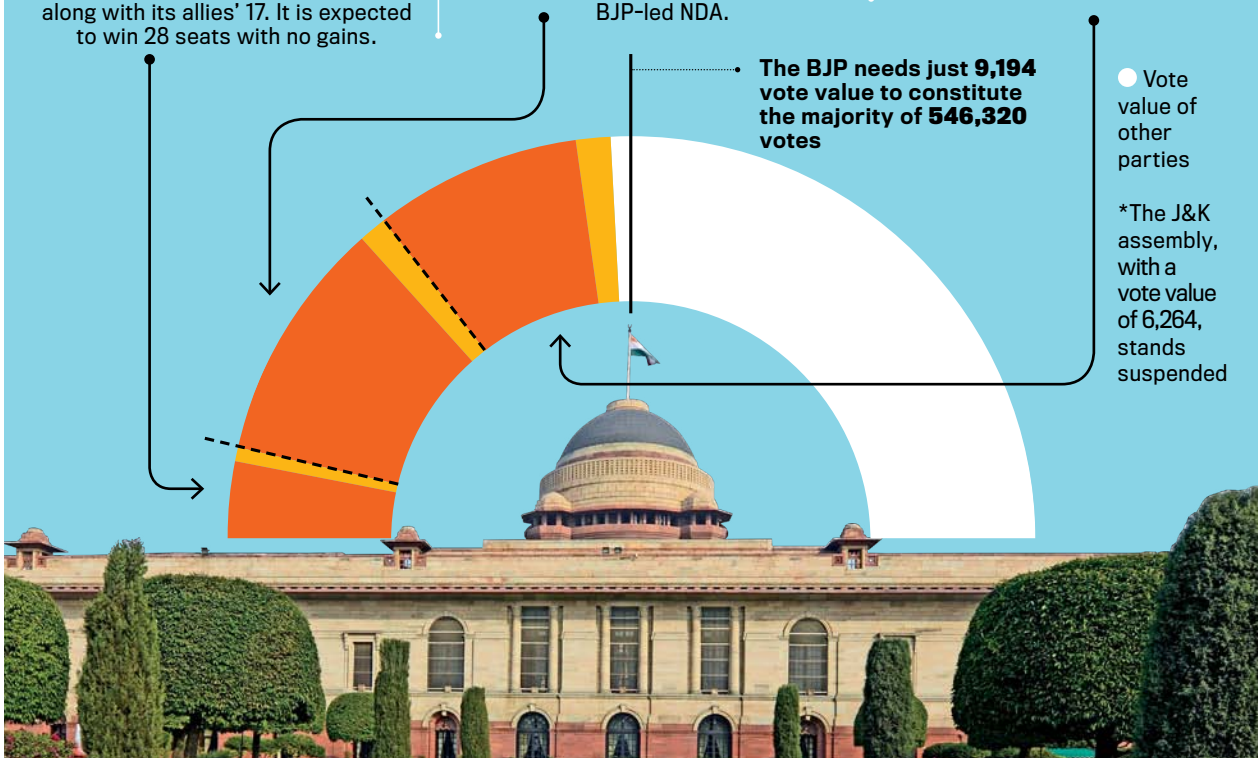
BJP **213,108** | ALLIES **25,488**

The 543-member hall has 708 votes for every member. Of the total members, 337 are from the BJP-led NDA.

ASSEMBLIES

BJP **184,013** | ALLIES **33,805**

The BJP has 1,376 MLAs in assemblies across the country, out of a possible 4,120



RAJWANT RAWAT

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